

attempted to reassert their rule, the commoners of both courts banded together in resistance. The Accordance War was as much an effort to prevent a return to the War of the Courts as it was a movement for commoner independence. When High King David negotiated an end to the Accordance War, he recognized the strength the commoners gained by working together despite their court differences. He made sure the Compact remained in effect for all changelings, even those newly returned from Arcadia.

While by far a better solution than open warfare, the Compact does not bring true equality to the courts. Jealousy still lurks just beneath the surface in some quarters. Currently, the Seelie Court holds more territory throughout the world. Even the High King of Concordia, in place since the Resurgence, is himself a member of Seelie Court. The Unseelie Court, and a few members of the Seelie Court, say the current situation is unsustainable. They point to global warming and the rise in extreme weather — droughts, wild fires, unprecedented numbers of hurricanes — as evidence that the world is growing increasingly out of balance. Changelings in power dismiss these claims as baseless fearmongering. After all, they say, the current environmental disasters were caused by human actions that began well before the Resurgence. Besides, the Seelie Court insists, Banality is too entrenched, and the Kithain's situation is too precarious, to risk the chaos that might follow radical changes in leadership right now.

Attitudes and Society

The barriers between the courts are lower today than at any other time in the history of the Kithain. Members of one court may travel freely through the territory of another court while freeholds are open to shelter all changelings regardless of their court. The preservation of the Dreaming and the cultivation of Glamour are the highest priorities for both courts. History has taught them through many a hard-earned lesson that they are able to accomplish these tasks much more effectively when they work together than when they're at each other's throats. Households, motleys, and oathcircles almost universally have at least one member from an opposing court. Just as all Kithain have a secondary Legacy that influences them, nearly all changelings have adopted a concept or behavior from an opposing court after so many years of interaction.

An individual's court marks her in a myriad of ways as she follows her chosen code. Her code guides her in all aspects of her life from her approach to problem solving, to her methods of cultivating Glamour, to even how she interacts with her friends and loved ones. While it's unusual for changelings to physically mark themselves as a member of one court or the other, a changeling's court affiliation is rarely a secret. So thoroughly is her identity wrapped up in her court's values that changelings can usually determine one another's court by appearance alone. The way she carries herself, her word choice, and certainly her reaction to opposition are clear markers of her court to other Kithain. Despite working together so closely since the Interregnum, millennia of prejudice and hostility is difficult to overcome — especially for the sidhe who have only

recently returned. The first reaction between two changelings of opposite courts meeting for the first time is almost always distrust. They can overcome this feeling with time, but it does take getting to know each other before they become truly comfortable with one another.

Court Membership

Before the fae underwent the Changeling Way, court was determined entirely by Legacy. Thanks to the influence of his adopted humanity, a changeling may attempt to follow the code of a court opposite of his Legacy. This is an extremely difficult path for a changeling to walk, and individuals who choose this route are exceedingly rare. The Seelie and Unseelie codes were established in the service of the Seelie and Unseelie Legacies. They are codes of conduct that all members of a court can agree on. For a changeling attempting to follow the code of an opposing court, it often feels like a struggle against the core of his very being. He must be constantly aware of even the smallest of his actions, otherwise habit will invariably cause him to violate a tenet of his chosen code.

Somewhat more common are changelings sworn to a noble house aligned to a court opposite the individual's Legacy. Every house is dedicated to the cause of the Seelie or Unseelie Court. To swear membership to a house is to swear to uphold the house's goals. In this case, the changeling usually follows the code of the court aligned with his Legacy, but he acts on the code in such a way as to further the interests of his house. The different houses have different degrees to which they tolerate a member out of step with the house's court. House Daanan welcomes Seelie changelings in its ranks. However, House Gwydion has very little patience for any member who would claim to be Unseelie.

Switching courts is never undertaken lightly. It almost always means the changeling is also switching his Legacies and, in doing so, changing his identity on a deep and fundamental level. Changing Legacies is always caused by a great transformation in a changeling's life, generally due to a major trauma or his worldview being shattered. If the changeling is only switching courts and not Legacies, it's because his former court is no longer able to support his new revelation. In either case, the changeling finds his place in Kithain society completely transformed. He will probably find that those closest to him view him differently even if they remain friends. Because it is such a profound change, an individual who switches courts usually tries to tie the change to a symbolic time of the year, such as during the Beltane or Samhain festivities. This tends to ease the transition for the changeling and those who know him.

The Seelie Court

The Seelie Court is the embodiment of the unrelenting heat of summer combined with the rejuvenating growth of spring. The court exemplifies light, new life, and order. It sees itself as the protector of Kithain society and the guardian of Glamour. Above all, the Seelie Court values community the most.